

Chapter 3

Reluctant Rivals II—China-US Relations under Biden, Containment and the Battle for Values



For most of the post-WWII era, the inevitable see-saw flip between Democratic and Republican in the presidency has demonstrated very different approaches. While generally seen as liberal versus conservative domestically, the two parties' policy on China has been similarly tough under presidents from both parties.

As we have seen in the previous chapter and in the wider news media since his reelection, Donald Trump has both engaged China, but also been very tough in terms of trade and national security. His main focus has been on the trade deficit, the perceived technological threat that China poses to the US and domestic concerns about certain groups of international students, which have indirectly also affected China.

However, Joe Biden, who we will take a closer look at in this chapter, while generally not as hawkish on China specifically, focused to a greater extent on ideological issues and containing an increasingly capable China led by the Communist Party. The Summit for Democracy, which was convened by President Biden, focused on strengthening democracy around the world and sent a very clear message to China, Russia and other states seen as “autocratic” that they were not welcome and were not considered equal in the discussion.

For China, this feeling of containment and exclusion was further exacerbated by the formation and expansion of security focused alliances like AUKUS and the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, which united traditional “Western Leaning” allies in reaction to China’s increased influence in the region, mostly economic, but also increasingly political.

While President Biden and his liberal democratic allies may have been more measured and diplomatic in their language regarding China compared to the direct and often incendiary language of Donald Trump, they similarly viewed China as a rival and potential danger to the United States both economically and strategically. In this chapter, we will look back at the Biden presidency to provide a bit of contrast and comparison to the current state of US-China relations under Trump 2.0.

As mentioned in the previous chapter, China and the United States have become increasingly intertwined in recent decades, forming a very close, if not nearly symbiotic relationship. Like all close relationships, Sino-US Relations have been going through a rough patch and in the first article of this chapter, “Rocking US-China Relationship Could Benefit from Couples Therapy”, the concepts of mutual respect, empathy and common interests are emphasized as ways to address the strained times that the US and China seem to be experiencing.

The visit by Anthony Blinken during the Biden administration was a welcome overture that signaled a possible warming of relations, but it still belied the complexities of the US-China relationship. The second article in this chapter, “Biden’s National Security Strategy Highlights the Paradox of US-China Relations”, highlights the fact that the US-China relationship is filled with areas of both cooperation and competition, the balance of which will require careful statecraft by both sides.

However, it is cooperation that will provide the greatest benefit to the US and China, as well as the rest of the world. The third article in this chapter highlights, “Stakes Have Never Been Higher for US-China Cooperation to Get into Gear”. The article identifies where the United States and China already cooperated effectively in the pursuit of peace in the Middle East, on climate change, and in the digital sphere, but that it is critical at this juncture that cooperation is put into high gear.

To promote cooperation, the most effective method is in-person communication. While this was nearly impossible during the COVID-19 pandemic, the next article in this chapter, “To Mend Fraying Sino-US Relations, Nothing Can Beat Face-to-Face Interaction” proposes three concrete recommendations to repair and restore Sino-US relations in the light of the current rise in tension.

Avoiding the Thucydides’s Trap

The discussion of the Thucydides’s Trap has captivated the imagination of the world in its desire to explain the current trend in US-China relations. The reference to the ancient conflict between the rising power of Greece and the incumbent power of Sparta, which resulted in outright war, has caused many people to draw direct and destructive conclusions. The next article in this chapter, “A Path Beyond the Thucydides’s Trap for China, US”, lays out the ways in which today’s situation is different and how all out war can be avoided.

One of the ways to avoid conflict is to promote more regular meetings at high levels of government. The next article in this chapter, “US-China Relations: Restarting Congressional Visits to the Mainland to Revive Dialogue and Understanding”, begins with the issue of visits by members of the US Congress to Taiwan and their impact on US-China relations, Beijing will continue to oppose these trips, but it can also welcome these members of Congress to visit the mainland to open up greater channels of person-to-person communication.

Another strategy for improving Sino-US relations is to use a different approach. In the next article in this chapter, “The Olympic Spirit Can Help Foster Sino-US Ties”, the spirit of friendly competition exemplified by the Olympics is used as an alternative to become “Higher, Faster, Stronger—Together”. In this next article, the most fundamental medium of communication-education-is touched upon in encouraging

dialogue among young people, who will ultimately decide where our future leads. In “How Restoring Youth Exchanges Can Build Future Bridges between China and the US”, the impact of youth and student exchange is discussed on as a fundamental tool in reestablishing connections between the US and China.

After two U.S. administrations and eight years of US pressure and containment on China, China has remained resilient, continuing to grow and evolve. Unlike the former Soviet Union, China is deeply interwoven with both the US and the global economy, making any separation difficult. This interconnectedness may gradually guide both nations toward a more pragmatic approach, finding common ground for peaceful coexistence. As Joseph Nye said in a dialogue with me, US-China relations often follow a cycle, and while we are currently at a low point, there is potential for recovery. Similarly, Graham Allison noted to me, the Thucydides’s Trap is not inevitable, and with mutual understanding and cooperation, it can be avoided.

US-China relations are among the most consequential in the world, impacting global stability and growth. The two have a shared responsibility to navigate and strive to resolve the problems of climate, economic development, and conflict. The international community looks to these two powers to foster a more balanced and cooperative relationship. While uncertainties remain, constructive efforts from both sides can pave the way for a stable, mutually beneficial path forward.

Rocking US-China Relationship Could Benefit from Couples Therapy Strategies¹

Antony Blinken's successful visit to Beijing has opened a window of opportunity to establish a more constructive and harmonious US-China relationship.

Conflict is inevitable in any long-term relationship. What really matters is whether partners can manage, resolve, and move on from their disagreements and build a healthier bond over time. This insight applies to international diplomacy as much as to romantic relationships.

It is fair to say the aftermath of the balloon incident in February was not a shining example of conflict resolution. Rather than communicating calmly and effectively, China and the United States got caught in a cycle of blame and recrimination, sending the relationship to its lowest ebb in decades.

Thankfully, US Secretary of State Antony Blinken's successful visit to Beijing has opened a window of opportunity to establish a more constructive and harmonious US-China relationship. Both sides have a responsibility to seize this chance—as two of the world's foremost powers, their dynamic not only influences their own nations but the entire global landscape.

Blinken's visit, the first to China by a US Secretary of State in five years, saw constructive meetings with the then Foreign Minister, top diplomat Wang Yi and President Xi Jinping, the last of which was by no means guaranteed. These positive interactions send a strong signal that, having veered dangerously close to the edge, both sides recognise they cannot risk a complete break and are committed to putting the relationship on a more steady footing.

It is now crucial for China and the US to work together to build a solid foundation for their relationship so that future incidents cannot derail ties in the manner we have seen in the last few months. To achieve this, there are four principles drawn from relationship therapy that can be adapted to help guide the development of stronger, more stable US-China relations.

First, open and regular communication is the cornerstone of any strong partnership. China and the US must get back to having frequent and transparent dialogue about their intentions, concerns, and expectations.

The first priority is to step up high-level interactions to clear the way for a meeting between Xi and US President Joe Biden at the Group of 20 or APEC summits later this year. Hopefully Blinken's trip will be followed by visits by US Treasury Secretary Janet Yellen, Commerce Secretary Gina Raimondo and Biden's climate envoy John Kerry.

Regular contacts at lower levels of government should also be restored, as well as the bilateral dialogue that withered during the Trump administration. Collectively, these meetings can provide platforms to explore avenues for cooperation and address any brewing issues and defuse tensions before they snowball into larger conflicts.

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Second, any relationship needs robust mechanisms to manage and resolve conflict when it does occur. China and the US must establish channels for swift and effective communication during crises, as well as pre-established protocols to manage such events, to help de-escalate such situations before they become unmanageable.

Even at the height of the Cold War, the US and Soviet Union maintained channels for communication and crisis management, including a hotline between Washington and Moscow. China and the US lack those kinds of mechanisms.

Looking to the longer term, the third point that a relationship therapist might emphasise is the need to develop mutual respect, empathy and shared interests. Couples going through a rough patch are often advised to try to understand the other person and engage in joint activities or hobbies to strengthen their bond.

In a similar vein, nations can foster empathy through cultural exchange in areas such as education, research, and tourism, helping to enhance mutual understanding and reduce the “us versus them” mentality. Cultural ties between China and the US have waned in recent years because of politics and the COVID-19 pandemic.

China is now open again, but the lack of sufficient flights to and from the US remains a bottleneck. Fewer than 6 per cent of flights between China and the US that existed in 2019 have resumed, according to a recent Nomura report, and flights that remain are expensive. Part of the issue is that restrictions on flying over Russian airspace add a significant cost to operating these routes. Both sides need to explore ways to increase the number of flights.

More broadly, both sides should strive to promote bilateral exchange across society. The number of US students in China dwindled to just around 350 last semester. Hopefully this number will begin to rise as students make new applications for next term. It would also be beneficial to promote academic exchange, including by reducing the red tape involved in having foreign guests participate in academic conferences in China.

Meanwhile, the Fulbright China programme sent US scholars to China for more than four decades and sent their Chinese counterparts the other way. It was canceled in 2020 but should be revived, as should the Peace Corps programme, which withdrew from China the same year.

Finally, shared goals and collaborative projects play a pivotal role in helping couples and continues deepen connections. Similarly, China and the US must identify areas of common ground and pursue joint initiatives that benefit both nations. This should extend beyond addressing immediate concerns and conflicts to encompass broader, more constructive themes such as climate change and global financial stability. Long-term collaboration and incremental achievements on such issues can help unite both nations under a common cause.

Like successful couples, both nations must invest time and effort in nurturing their partnership. After Blinken’s visit, there is a chance for China and the US to build a more solid foundation for their relationship so it is not derailed when the next surprise comes. As with any relationship, there will be bumps in the road, but these can be overcome with careful management.

Biden's National Security Strategy Highlights the Paradox of US-China Relations²

Biden's strategy proposes a "dual-track approach" that allows for cooperation with any country—including geopolitical rivals—and calling for "responsible competition" with China.

The author F. Scott Fitzgerald famously wrote: "The test of a first-rate intelligence is the ability to hold two opposing ideas in mind at the same time and still retain the ability to function."

In the coming decades, as American scholar Graham Allison notes, the leaders of China and the United States will face something akin to this "Fitzgerald test" as they seek to navigate an increasingly fraught relationship.

On one hand, it seems inevitable that the two countries will be fierce competitors as both strive to be the biggest and best across a range of economic, technological, and military arenas. On the other hand, unless they can cooperate in dealing with shared threats like climate change, both countries—along with the rest of the world—are doomed.

This tension between competition and cooperation permeates the bilateral relationship and remains an unresolved contradiction in President Biden's national security strategy, which was finally released last week.

First, it is welcome that the strategy recognises that shared challenges like climate change, food insecurity, pandemics and inflation are "at the core of national and international security and must be treated as such". In the twenty-first century, no country can be truly safe unless it works with others to address such shared issues, which are not only a direct threat to national security, but also risk multipliers for geopolitical instability.

Biden's strategy mentions "climate" around 65 times—a welcome change from the version issued by the Trump administration, which eschewed fighting climate change in favour of calls for energy dominance and fossil fuel production.

However, it is difficult to square Biden's avowed commitment to global cooperation on shared threats with the overriding emphasis on geopolitical competition, particularly with China, which suffuses every section of the document.

China is an indispensable partner if the US is serious about tackling global threats like climate change. The two countries are the world's largest economies, carbon emitters, and suppliers of clean technology. They are also the world's two science superpowers, jointly accounting for about 40 per cent of global scholarly output and over one-third of the world's 8.85 million research personnel.

China-US collaboration in research and innovation will be critical to addressing climate change, pandemics, and other challenges that no country can handle alone. But these links are already suffering amid rising bilateral tensions. Last year, China-US co-publications fell for the first time and at least 1,400 US-based ethnic Chinese scientists switched their affiliation from US to Chinese institutions.

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Biden is now escalating competition with China in science and technology—not only by investing in America's capabilities, but also by actively trying to hold back China's development, as seen in the recent sweeping restrictions on semiconductors.

Moves like this will only deepen the chill in bilateral cooperation at a time when we should be seeking closer integration between the vast science and research ecosystems of both countries to tap synergies and develop solutions to global challenges.

Sanctions on semiconductors will not only affect China, which is the world's largest buyer of chips. Bifurcating the market will also have a major impact on economies such as Taiwan, South Korea, and Japan that supply components to mainland China, hurting profits, research and ultimately the development of an industry that is so crucial for growth and innovation.

More broadly, the US's drive to pit democracies against autocracies, as laid out in the security strategy, does not resonate well in Asia and many other regions. It will work against the economic integration, prosperity and harmony that is required to mobilise joint resources and forge the inclusive global governance that is required to deal with our shared threats.

Biden's strategy does pay lip service to the contradiction between its two stated priorities of shared challenges and geopolitical competition, proposing a "dual-track approach" that allows for cooperation with any country—including geopolitical rivals—and calling for "responsible competition" with China.

However, these remain abstract notions and there is little indication of how they can be realised in practice, or how the US hopes to promote global cooperation while pitting a select group of like-minded countries against others.

Thankfully, both sides still have the political will to work together, whatever their differences. In a press conference just before the opening of the Communist Party congress, senior official Sun Yeli said that the most important thing in international relations in the next 50 years would be "a right way" for the US and China "to get along".

Last week, Secretary of State Antony Blinken reiterated that the US must not lose sight of the cooperative aspects of the relationship, recognising that problems like climate change and global health will be difficult to solve if the two nations are not engaged.

Biden's new strategy highlights the question of how the US and China can cooperate and compete at the same time in a world of growing tensions. For now, the answer to that paradox remains a work in progress. Solving it will require creative statecraft by leaders living up to the Fitzgerald test of juggling two seemingly contradictory ideas at the same time.

Stakes Have Never Been Higher for US-China Cooperation to Get into Gear³

Recent high-level talks between China and the US on climate change and ongoing wars highlight the potential for successful collaboration and call for even more bilateral coordination.

The visit of China's special envoy for climate change, Liu Zhenmin, to the United States on May 8–9 was one of many recent interactions highlighting renewed momentum in US-China relations. The visit included discussions with the new US climate envoy John Podesta on deploying technologies to reduce emissions of greenhouse gases like methane.

This event underscores a broader trend of increased interactions between the US and China, such as the recent Harvard Kennedy School China Conference, where the responsibilities of both nations in maintaining global peace were emphasised.

A notable example of successful cooperation is the recent handling of Iran-Israel tensions. Intelligence about a potential escalation after Israel's attack on an Iranian consulate building in Damascus prompted US Secretary of State Antony Blinken to call Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi and request China's intervention.

Wang contacted his Iranian counterpart, urging restraint. This intervention no doubt helped temper Iran's retaliation against Israel, showcasing how China and the US can collaborate to support world peace.

In an increasingly interconnected world beset by conflict and facing profound challenges in areas such as artificial intelligence (AI), climate change, cybersecurity and space exploration, the need for US-China cooperation has never been more pressing.

As two of the world's superpowers, both nations bear a unique and shared moral responsibility to address these critical issues collaboratively. Their partnership is essential not only for resolving existing tensions but also for steering the world towards a more stable and prosperous future.

During his recent visit to Beijing, Blinken spoke of the duty great nations share to ensure stability, a sentiment echoed by Wang Yi. This dialogue builds on the 2023 "San Francisco vision" and the phone call in April this year between US President Joe Biden and Chinese President Xi Jinping.

The two sides have continued to communicate over the war in Ukraine and Israel's war on Gaza, signaling a mutual desire to ease various tensions through diplomacy and dialogue. Looking ahead, they should deepen cooperation within multilateral frameworks like the United Nations to address regional conflicts, a profound test for the rules-based global order.

Moving forward, it is essential that the two countries focus on several key areas of cooperation. Foremost among these is the issue of peace and stability, which stands as the most pressing challenge facing humanity today. The escalating violence in Gaza

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and the Russia-Ukraine war acutely underscore the urgent need for global stability and joint efforts to ensure peace.

The US and China should take proactive steps to mediate ongoing conflicts. President Xi has already stepped up China's diplomatic efforts in the Gaza crisis, along with French President Emmanuel Macron, urging Israel to refrain from its proposed ground offensive in Rafah and advocating for the necessary humanitarian corridors and a two-state solution. Similarly, Beijing has encouraged Russia and Ukraine to begin peace talks to prevent further escalation. Both China and the US can also do more to work through the UN to establish and support peacekeeping missions and diplomatic initiatives in conflict zones.

Another critical area of cooperation is on climate change. The US and China, as the world's largest carbon emitters, have a responsibility to lead global efforts in mitigating their impact on the climate. More than other nations, they should jointly spearhead initiatives within the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change to ensure the successful implementation of the Paris Agreement.

Potential collaborative projects could include funding for renewable energy research, sharing green technologies, and providing financial as well as technical support to developing countries.

Meanwhile, the rise of AI presents both opportunities and challenges that demand cooperative governance. On May 14, the first US-China intergovernmental dialogue on AI took place in Geneva. Yang Tao, director general of the foreign ministry's North American and Oceanian Affairs department, led the Chinese delegation while Tarun Chhabra, senior director for technology and national security at the National Security Council, and Seth Center, the State Department's acting special envoy for critical and emerging technology, headed the US side.

The delegations discussed their approaches to managing AI risks and emphasised the importance of ensuring AI technologies are beneficial, safe, and equitable. There is an urgent need for the US and China to collaborate on establishing international norms and standards for AI development and deployment. Bilateral agreements on AI ethics and safety protocols could help mitigate risks and ensure that AI technologies serve the greater good.

The strengthening of multilateral institutions is essential to building a new international order that reflects contemporary realities. The US and China should champion reform of global institutions like the UN, World Bank, and the International Monetary Fund, advocating for more inclusive decision-making processes that empower developing countries. By doing so, they will enhance the legitimacy and effectiveness of these institutions.

In addition to national-level exchanges, promoting people-to-people exchanges is also vital for reducing mutual distrust and fostering understanding between the people of these two nations. Expanding educational and cultural exchanges, easing visa restrictions, and encouraging collaborative academic research are essential steps. These initiatives can help build trust and dispel misconceptions, laying the groundwork for a more cooperative future.

The need for US-China cooperation could not be more urgent. By rising above short-sighted rivalries, the two Pacific powers can work to build a cooperative international order that promotes security for humanity as a whole rather just than their own national security interests. The choices the US and China make today will resonate across generations and hopefully shape a world where peace and prosperity are achieved through collective action and shared responsibility.

To Mend Fraying Sino-US Relations, Nothing Can Beat Face-to-Face Interaction⁴

CCG led Track II outreach at the end of the COVID-19 pandemic with a ten day trip covering North America, Europe, and Asia to signal a return to in-person engagement by China.

Engagement is not just a foreign policy stance. It is also a web of bilateral relationships between both individuals and institutions, including government agencies and a diverse array of civil organisations, universities, think tanks and business groups.

Unfortunately, in recent years, such links between China and the United States have frayed amid political tensions and the pandemic.

Earlier this month, a delegation from the Centre for China Globalization (CCG) visited the US for 10 days, hoping to make a small contribution to rebuilding these bilateral ties. The trip was part of an engagement tour that also took us to Berlin, Brussels, Paris, Seoul, and Singapore.

In New York and Washington, we met representatives from 30 institutions, including prominent think tanks, business leaders, journalists and officials from the US State Department and the Chinese embassy. To our knowledge, it was the first such visit to the US by a Chinese think tank delegation since the pandemic began.

Having returned to China, three takeaways from the trip stand out.

First, it is clear the “human architecture” of China-US relations has atrophied over the past three years. By this, I mean the stock of knowledge, expertise and interpersonal connections that allow the two countries to understand and communicate with each other.

Before the pandemic, the CCG would make several trips to engage with its US counterparts each year, part of a tide of bilateral exchange that saw 14,000 people traveling from China to America each day.

In recent years, bilateral tensions have taken a toll on this interaction. At the governmental level, regular meetings such as annual strategic and economic dialogues have ceased. There has been a chilling effect on academic exchange and research collaboration. With the outbreak of COVID-19, these cross-border flows have reduced to a trickle.

Organisations such as our think tank have adapted by using virtual platforms to engage with our counterparts on the other side of the Pacific. But, as our recent trip brought home, this is no substitute for in-person exchange when it comes to the candour, depth of conversation and social bonding necessary for effective communication and trust building.

Meeting old friends in the US, who, like me, are not getting any younger, I was reminded that part of maintaining a healthy China-US relationship is cultivating new talent that can help manage differences and bridge the divide between the two countries.

An older generation of China watchers, many with strong language skills, deep personal ties to China, and extensive knowledge of the country, are gradually leaving

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the stage in Washington. No doubt, there are many bright minds in the upcoming generation.

But they are also coming of age in a more hawkish political environment and have been unable to visit China for the past three years, which will surely affect their understanding of contemporary China and its language. This can only be detrimental to China-US relations in the long run.

My second takeaway from our US trip gives more reason for optimism. Despite a hardening of views towards China over the past two years, there is still a great desire to better understand China among US policymakers, academics and business leaders, and there is a significant constituency still committed to working for a more constructive bilateral relationship.

Our delegation was warmly received wherever we went in New York and Washington. All the events we participated in ran over time, such was the hunger for discussion and the volume of questions people wanted to ask about China.

This was particularly so for the business groups we met, such as the US-China Business Council and the US Chamber of Commerce. Despite concerns over the worsening of China-US relations and the war in Ukraine, we found that, in general, the US business executives we spoke to remain pragmatic towards China and tend to be less hawkish than the prevailing view in the US media.

We encountered many misperceptions about China, but also great curiosity and an eagerness to return to the country. Several business leaders we met, including US-China Business Council President Craig Allen, were among the founding members of a new group that declared its aims to rebuild US relations with China in an op-ed in *The Wall Street Journal* on July 6.

Building on the first two observations, my third and final takeaway from our trip is that it is crucial for both sides to work to restore interpersonal exchanges as soon as possible. Zoom cannot replace in-person interaction when it comes to building trust and understanding.

The pandemic has smothered this channel at a time when global cooperation is sorely needed to address the crisis of compounding risks, from inflation and food shortages to the pandemic and climate change.

China must continue to protect the health of its citizens. But more steps could be taken to facilitate the return of foreign students and outbound trips by Chinese scholars, such as allowing more international flights and easing restrictions on entry and exit.

One think-tank expert we spoke to suggested that China could adopt a form of the closed-loop model, as used in the Winter Olympics, enabling US citizens to visit and meet Chinese counterparts face to face.

Thankfully, China's policies are moving in the right direction to allow personal exchanges to resume. When we met the then Chinese Ambassador to the US in Washington, he asked us to convey the message to our US counterparts that China welcomes more interaction between businesses and institutions.

Premier Li Keqiang reiterated this message recently, in a World Economic Forum dialogue, saying that international students may return to China to continue their studies if they wish, and pledging to improve visa policies and other steps to facilitate cross-border travel. Hopefully, our trip to the US will be the first of many and will signal a resumption of academic and cultural exchange between the two countries.

A Path beyond the Thucydides's Trap for China, US⁵

Far from a “fatalist” view on US-China relations, Graham Allison believes that there is a path that can avoid the Thucydides's Trap and the potentially destructive conflict it foretells.

On March 27, the country's top leader President Xi and a group of US businesspeople and academics agreed that the existing and rising powers can avoid the “Thucydides's Trap”. The meeting was held just days after the release of the book, *Escaping Thucydides's Trap: Dialogue with Graham Allison on China-US Relations*, at the Center for China and Globalization. The timing of the book is critical, because the US presidential election in November will likely define the future of US-China relations amid a complex geopolitical landscape marked by trade disputes and regional conflicts.

In recent years, I have engaged in numerous discussions with Graham Allison, a leading analyst of national security, at events at the CCG as elsewhere around the world which led to the creation of our book. Through a series of questions and answers, we have examined the dynamics between rising and established powers, seeking paths for peaceful competition between China and the United States.

On March 22, 2024, Allison and I jointly released the English and the Chinese editions of the book at CCG's headquarters in Beijing. At the book launch, we also had a number of meaningful discussions on the future of Sino-US ties that drew on key themes from the book. Allison, who first articulated the concept of the “Thucydides's Trap”, addressed the matter head-on: a US-China rivalry may be inevitable, but so is cooperation when our need for survival requires it.

It all began with Thucydides, considered by some as the father of history, who introduced a key concept in his seminal work, *The History of the Peloponnesian War*. The concept is essential to the analysis of history, highlighting the perilous power dynamics between rising and ruling powers. At the heart of his analysis is the Thucydides's Trap—an almost inevitable conflict that ensues when a rapidly rising power, such as Athens in ancient times, poses a significant threat to an established dominant power, such as Sparta. This dynamic, illustrating the tension between an emergent force and the established power, made the Peloponnesian War almost inevitable.

If we look at today's global landscape, we can see that no country in history has risen as rapidly and extensively in such a short time as China has. From a country where, till the 1990s, 90 percent of the population lived on less than \$2 a day, China has not only succeeded in eradicating extreme poverty but has also become the world's largest economy in terms of purchasing power parity.

The fact that this remarkable transformation has occurred in four decades and is unprecedented, has made the US uncomfortable only because having shaped the post-World War II international order and been the sole superpower after the end of the Cold War, it struggles to accept the rise of an equally powerful country. This is where the Thucydides's Trap comes in.

⁵ First published on April 25, 2024 by *China Daily* and revised for this collection.

Moreover, trade tensions, geopolitical challenges, and issues such as the Taiwan question have become flashpoints in US-China relations, emphasizing the need to avoid the “Thucydides’s Trap” because, now, more than ever, collaboration is crucial.

During the book launch, Allison used a compelling analogy to illustrate the intricate China-US interdependence. He likened the two countries to “conjoined twins”, sharing vital organs but with two distinct heads and minds, and bound by the existential imperative to “coexist or perish”. This drives home the point that engaging in harmful actions, even if momentarily satisfying, ultimately results in self-harm.

This concept aligns with the Chinese phrase, “you are in me, and I am in you”, which President Xi Jinping quoted during a meeting with a bipartisan US Senate delegation, including Democrat Senator Charles Schumer, on Oct 9, 2023. This notion is rooted in Chinese culture and contrasts with the often binary “black and white” thinking that marks discourse in the US, advocating instead for a more intertwined and connected approach.

President Xi was the first global leader to truly explore the concept of “Thucydides’s Trap”, even before the publication of *Destined for War: Can America and China Avoid Thucydides’s Trap?* in 2017. He has often said that there is no inherent “Thucydides’s Trap” in the world but that strategic miscalculations among major powers could inadvertently create one.

As a student and colleague of former US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger, Allison shares Kissinger’s perspective that Sino-US relations are perilously poisoned, yet insists that coexistence is achievable. He believes that through steadfast communication and thoughtful diplomacy, major powers can transcend the historical inevitabilities that Thucydides described.

In his role as a Harvard professor and former US government official, Allison significantly influences the narrative on US-China relations. He argues that cooperation between the two countries is not just mutually beneficial, but also essential for survival. So the two powers should work together by setting aside their differences and focusing on their fundamental interests—chief among them is national survival.

The idea of interconnection has broader implications, especially considering the fragmented nature of the current global order, which lacks a common goal for collective action. It further underscores the necessity of exploring strategies to bridge divides and establish a framework for peaceful competition. Such was the impetus behind Allison’s seminal work, *Destined for War*.

His follow-up work, *Escaping Thucydides’s Trap*, directly responds to his earlier analysis based on our robust dialogue on preventing conflict. This dialogue critically examines the triggers that could lead to war and proposes viable strategies for steering clear of the Thucydides’s Trap, drawing on historical lessons that underscore the possibility and necessity of peaceful coexistence.

In his new book, Allison refutes the “fatalist” view on potential conflict between the US and China, asserting that a conflict is “not inevitable” and, instead, advocates for adjustments in behavior and proactive steps to prevent a tragedy of historic proportions. Unlike many Western figures who view China primarily as a threat, Allison objectively views China’s progress, respects its right to development, and lauds its achievements, and supports constructive competition, comparing it to the Olympics.

US-China Relations: Restarting Congressional Visits to Mainland to Revive Dialogue and Understanding⁶

With Congress playing a bigger role than ever in the US-China relationship, it is important for Beijing to restart face-to-face interaction with US delegations; not doing so would carry risks.

Congress has arguably never played a bigger role in the US-China relationship. Since the 118th Congress convened in January, lawmakers have introduced a lengthy series of China-related bills, met Taiwan's president, Tsai Ing-wen, in both the United States and Taipei, questioned TikTok's CEO, and formed a new select committee that has labeled the Communist Party an "existential threat" to the US.

After this flurry of events, it is perhaps no wonder that the US Congress is seen as a hawkish and destabilising influence in US-China relations, at least in Beijing. But it has not always been this way.

After the "Red Scare" of McCarthyism in the 1950s, congressional activities such as the 1966 Senate hearings on China played a key role in building a climate in which rational discussion could take place again. It was driven by figures with a deep interest in Asia, such as senators Mike Mansfield and J. William Fulbright.

After President Richard Nixon's historic visit to China, Mansfield and Fulbright were among the legislators who visited China between 1972 and 1978 as part of congressional delegations. As the administration's outreach to China waned with Nixon's downfall and amid President Gerald Ford's domestic preoccupations, these delegations became the most active channel of communication between the two governments to reach agreements on normalising relations.

These early visits, generally followed by reports and hearings that provided first-hand evaluations of China, played an important role in helping the rest of Congress and the broader American public understand China's political system, its attitude towards the US, and the importance of improving bilateral relations.

Candid discussions with legislators helped Chinese leaders understand the dynamics and positions of Congress. The visits also served to promote economic cooperation in fields such as agriculture and aviation and left a strong impression on lawmakers who would go on to play key roles in shaping US foreign policy, including a young Joe Biden who made his first trip to China in 1979.

In recent decades, delegations of members of Congress and their staff have continued to visit China, allowing them to meet senior Chinese officials and learn about China for themselves through site visits, study tours and meetings. However, these in-person exchanges, which were already declining before the COVID-19 pandemic, have come to a halt for the past three years.

At a time when tensions between the two powers have reached new heights, this lack of face-to-face interaction has exacerbated misunderstanding and a lack of trust. Now that China has reopened, it is time for a concerted effort to get US lawmakers to come back and see the country for themselves.

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Last year, almost 40 members of Congress went to Taiwan, the most in a decade, and this year more delegations have visited the island. Beijing will continue to oppose these trips, but it can also welcome them to visit the mainland. When the next high-profile visit happens, it would be smart to adopt a more proactive approach and invite lawmakers to visit the mainland.

Engaging with members of Congress directly would let Beijing present its own perspective on the visits and hopefully better manage these periodic disruptions to the US-China relationship. The Asia tour by Newt Gingrich in 1997 provides useful precedent, when the then-House speaker was persuaded to start his tour with a visit to the mainland for three days before going on to Taiwan via Tokyo.

Some lawmakers will refuse the invitation. Even so, there is no harm in China demonstrating openness and a willingness to engage with Congress. Some lawmakers—such as California Democrat Ro Khanna, a member of the Select Committee on China—have expressed a willingness to visit. Despite the appearance of a bipartisan hawkish consensus, there is a diversity of views in Congress and a willingness to pursue a multifaceted approach to China that does not foreclose the possibility of stabilising bilateral relations.

Managing these visits will be tricky. Chinese officials will have to engage constructively with guests who have to play to a domestic audience that demands they be “tough on China”, especially as the 2024 presidential election countdown begins.

Minds will not be changed in a single visit, but at this stage any chance to interact and present a different side of the story would be an improvement. First-person experience can be surprisingly effective in challenging preconceived ideas.

A year before his 1997 visit, Gingrich likened Beijing’s leadership to terrorists. After three days in China, he was pushing for stronger bilateral engagement and described meeting Chinese leaders as “the high point of my public life”.

Furthermore, Chinese lawmakers and top advisers should be encouraged to visit the US, so more direct exchanges and frank dialogue can be conducted for both countries.

Of course, much has changed since the Gingrich visit, and even more since Congress helped lay the groundwork for the normalisation of US-China relations in the 1970s. Geopolitically, the power balance between the two sides has narrowed and they have lost a common foe in the Soviet Union.

Competing with China has become a rare unifying cause in Congress. In the current climate, it is hard to imagine any lawmaker going out on a limb, as Mansfield did in the 1960s and 1970s, to advocate closer relations with China.

There is a significant gap between the world views of US lawmakers and Chinese officials, but it is surely no bigger than it was in the 1970s before China opened up to the world. For Beijing, engaging with US lawmakers will not be easy or without risk. Even so, it is surely a greater risk not to engage with Congress as it plays a growing role in shaping the US-China relationship.

The Olympic Spirit Can Help Foster Sino-US Ties⁷

Competition between the countries should reflect the spirit of Olympic competition, striving for excellence while supporting each other, which is crucial for advancing human progress.

The Paris Olympic Games were a milestone for China, as the country not only won 40 gold medals, tying with the United States for top gold medal count, but also celebrated its best ever performance at an overseas Olympics, showcasing its emergence as a global sports powerhouse.

This achievement marks a historical journey for China, from the moment in 1908 when it first expressed the wish to host its own Olympics to successfully hosting the Beijing 2008 Summer Olympics and then the Beijing 2022 Winter Olympics, becoming the world's first "dual Olympic city".

The breakthroughs China has achieved across different sports disciplines, including in tennis and cycling, mirrors the country's rise in economic, technological and social domains, paralleling developments that the West has often viewed as a challenge to the existing world order, particularly affecting China-US relations. However, China has emphasized that its rise is peaceful in nature, China has remained committed to maintaining a fairer and just world order.

Sino-US relations are one of the most critical bilateral relationships in the world today, influencing global politics, economics, and security. In the 45 years since the establishment of diplomatic relations between China and the United States, the two countries' relationship has weathered many storms only to move forward.

On Jan 1 this year, Chinese and US presidents exchanged congratulatory messages on the 45th anniversary of the establishment of China-US diplomatic ties. In the first seven months of this year, the total Sino-US trade volume reached 2.72 trillion yuan, marking a 4.1 percent increase. Among this, exports to the United States amounted to 2.04 trillion yuan, up by 5.1 percent.

As two of the five permanent members of the UN Security Council and nuclear powers, China and the US play key roles in maintaining global stability and promoting development. Yet bilateral relations face a series of challenges, including trade tensions, technological rivalry, and geopolitical disputes. The trade war initiated by the US in 2018 and characterized by punitive tariffs on Chinese goods not only harmed the two economies but also sent ripples across the global trade system. The high-tech competition between the two sides further intensified with the US imposing sanctions on Chinese technology firms in a bid to curb China's advancement in high-tech.

Besides, geopolitical issues including the South China Sea disputes—and the Taiwan question, which is China's internal matter—have made already fragile Sino-US ties more complex.

Amid all this, the Olympic Games offered valuable lessons for both China and the US. Sino-US ties should mirror the ethos of the Olympics, which embodies the spirit of friendly competition. The competition between the countries, regardless of the

⁷ First published on August 13, 2024 by *China Daily* and revised for this collection.

field, should be like any competition in the Olympics—to seek mutual accomplishment under the motto “Higher, Faster, Stronger—Together”. This spirit of striving for excellence while supporting each other in the process is crucial for advancing human progress.

The addition of “Together” to the Olympic motto in 2021 emphasizes the importance of solidarity, cooperation, and friendship among countries, a vision that resonates with China’s proposal to build a community with a shared future for mankind.

China has long championed the principle of “Friendship First, Competition Second”, a guiding tenet that has roots in the “ping-pong diplomacy” of 1971 which helped thaw Sino-US relations, as the two sides’ table tennis teams engaged in friendly matches that eventually led to a historic breakthrough in bilateral ties. After the breakthrough, the two countries began breaking down the barriers that had kept them apart for more than two decades. The ping-pong diplomacy shows that even the most entrenched divisions can be narrowed through sportsmanship and mutual respect.

The concept of cooperation is deeply embedded in the Olympic spirit. The Olympic rings, representing the five continents, symbolize unity and the collective effort of all countries to work together to achieve common goals.

The Olympics also underscore the importance of fair competition, a principle that the Chinese delegation has highlighted by advocating for “gold medals of morality, style, and integrity”, which reflects China’s commitment to fair play and commitment to maintain global peace and uphold global values, drawing international praise.

Olympic competitions are not zero-sum games; they are mutually beneficial and fulfilling events. During the ancient Olympic Games, people from different city-states in ancient Greece achieved mutual benefit and shared prosperity through friendly competition, cultural exchanges and trade. From its inception, the Olympic Games have promoted the values of mutual benefit and shared prosperity, extending beyond the realm of sports into the broader context of international relations.

Graham Allison, who popularized the concept of “Thucydides’s Trap”, recently suggested that positive competition, as represented by the Olympic spirit, should guide international relations. Indeed, the Olympic spirit, with its emphasis on friendly competition, cooperation and fairness, offers a powerful metaphor for the future of China-US relations.

As the two sides navigate the complexities of their relationship, they would do better to draw inspiration from the Olympic ideals. By embracing this spirit, they can move beyond the challenges that have strained their relations in recent years and work together to build a future where competition is constructive and cooperation valued, and the two sides contribute to the progress of humanity.

How Restoring Youth Exchanges Can Build Future Bridges Between China and the US⁸

The numbers of Americans in Chinese universities are historically low amid strained bilateral relations and China is implementing creative policies to attract both students and young professionals.

In a significant diplomatic gesture during his visit to the APEC summit in San Francisco last year, President Xi Jinping announced that China would invite 50,000 young Americans to take part in exchange and study programmes over the next five years.

This commitment to mend the cultural rift with the US was highlighted by the warm reception students from Muscatine High School in Iowa received when they visited China in late January. They also received a personal letter from President Xi.

Yet, such expressions of goodwill are not enough on their own. The number of American students enrolling in Chinese universities has dropped to its lowest level in a decade. According to a US government-funded study by the Institute of International Education, just 211 Americans studied in mainland China during the 2021–22 academic year.

In 2023, US Ambassador to China Nicholas Burns estimated there were about 350 American students enrolled in study abroad programmes in China. The COVID-19 pandemic, strained bilateral relations, and challenges such as the delayed resumption of direct flights have all played a part in this downturn.

It is imperative that the trend is reversed. The decline represents a lost opportunity for nearly a generation of young people to learn about China and potentially enhance the China-US relationship. Historically, students have been vital links, serving dual roles in public diplomacy as learners and influencers, fostering mutual understanding even when diplomatic and economic relations have soured.

If the US-China Science and Technology Agreement is renewed, it will offer a great opportunity for more young Americans to pursue their studies in China. However, there are several other initiatives that could also be implemented to further improve the situation. Exceptional programmes such as those at the Schwarzman College at Tsinghua University and at Yenching Academy at Peking University could play an essential role.

Showcasing the opportunities for educational and technological innovation through academic programmes could attract more international students and talent. Enhancing collaboration with US universities and exchange programmes like Duke Kunshan University and the Shanghai campus of New York University might attract more American students.

Policymakers should also consider streamlining visa processes and offering tax incentives for top-tier international educators. Such policies would make China more appealing for world-class scholars and enhance students' educational experience.

It is also essential to create engaging environments for students through work-study initiatives, career guidance, and innovation competitions that nurture a

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supportive environment. International students should be integrated into global talent schemes that enhance their job prospects by establishing partnerships with human resources firms, embassies and bodies such as the International Labour Organization.

Cultivating partnerships with organisations like the All-China Youth Federation, the Overseas Chinese Federation, international chambers of commerce, the All-China Women's Federation, and university alumni associations could help enrich these exchanges. By working with these groups, China can pave the way for a deeper and more nuanced understanding between young people in both countries.

Equally crucial is the development of a comprehensive public relations strategy aimed at fostering a welcoming environment. Sharing success stories and addressing potential concerns could help China shape a perception that not only reassures but ultimately attracts prospective international students and their families.

Practical steps to maximise the impact of exchanges is also extremely important. That means promoting collaborative academic projects, supporting mixed living arrangements and creating communal spaces to spur cultural exchanges. These steps not only facilitate shared learning experiences, but also help break down cultural barriers and foster mutual understanding.

In terms of financial aid and scholarship opportunities, the US could consider reinstituting the Fulbright Program or creating similar ones, while China could make scholarships more available and accessible for US students. Strengthening links between educational institutions, businesses, non-governmental organisations and think tanks in both countries is also crucial in diversifying exchange opportunities.

In the face of scepticism and misconceptions on both sides, China is working to provide an objective view of its complex identity. Especially in light of bilateral tensions, inviting more American students and young professionals to China is a critical step to enhance mutual exchanges and challenge global stereotypes.

This mission is especially significant considering the void left by scholars like Ezra Vogel and John Fairbank, whose work offered deep insights into China's culture and society. There is an incredible opportunity for young American scholars to rediscover China, experience the country first-hand and share what they find, like the pioneering scholars before them.

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